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Gerald Wiggins

Pianist Gerald Wiggins has been a fixture in the West Coast jazz scene for many years. Originally from New York, born in 1922, Gerald first made his mark with Les Hite, Louis Armstrong and Benny Carter. His West Coast work included stints in the film and recording studios and he accompanied numerous jazz vocalists, including Lena Horne and Kay Starr. Gerald can be heard at festivals and concerts across the country and still records with such artists as Red Holloway and Clark Terry.

Gerald was interviewed in Los Angeles on September 2, 1995 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming today on behalf of Hamilton College Jazz Archive. We are attending the L.A. Classic Jazz Festival and are really pleased today to be with a fine pianist and well-known jazz figure Gerald Wiggins.

GW: Hi.

MR: Pleased to meet you, and glad to finally find an hour — I know you are a busy man. It's a pleasure to talk to you. You're an East Coast man transplanted to the west?

GW: That's about it, yes.

MR: How did that come about?

GW: Well I was working with an old time comedian, Stepin Fetchit.

MR: Stepin Fetchit.

GW: Remember him?

MR: I like the name.

GW: Anyhow, we were working at the Brooklyn Strand and there was a west coast band backing the show by the name of Les Hite. Well the Army took Les Hite's piano player, and Step had a little problem he had to talk to the police about so he disappeared. So Les said to me, "You don't have a boss and I don't have a piano player. How would you like to go to California?" So I was young and crazy I said, "Great."

MR: And how old were you then?

GW: I must have been just about 18 then. I was just out of high school.

MR: Yeah. It's so interesting to hear the ages that a lot of folks we've talked to have started at. What kind of, just to step back once, what kind of piano playing did you do for Stepin?

GW: Well I was mostly part of his act. I had played some things and I had to help him with a few little things he did like he said, "Help me with this coat" and I put it up to his shoulder and he said, "the hand down there" and I had to drop it down and put it on his hand. It was really, you know, cornball stuff, but it made him a millionaire so what can I say?

MR: Then you traveled around doing little shows?

GW: We didn't do too—I didn't stay with him that long. I think we played maybe about four or five weeks. We went as far as Anderson, Indiana and came right back. At that time everything was weekend shows, you know, little towns. Friday and Saturday night was it.

MR: And this was after you went to, was there a high school in New York?

GW: The High School of Music and Art, yeah. Well I graduated in 1940.

MR: Was that a good experience there? Was that at that time—

GW: Music and art?

MR: Yeah.

GW: Fantastic. Oh it was something new, and we've got Mayor LaGuardia to thank for that. The only hang-up was that most of the students that went there were piano players. So we all had to take another instrument. I picked up the bass violin. Stupid me. I used to carry it home every night and bring it back the next morning. I got tired of that too.

MR: I'll bet.

GW: But that was a great education. We had, you know, regular school subjects, history and math and all the rest of it, but you had to keep up your grades in that too or out you go. But I got a chance to actually play in the symphony orchestra, and some great music. Things I never would have had a chance to play. So, and Benny Goodman used to come up with the trio every Friday. That was nice.

MR: At the — he'd play at the school?

GW: Yeah. That was a big treat, when you could get in, because it would be packed. Yeah it was quite a school.

MR: Great. And there was a certain amount — you learned at that point to read music but you must have developed your ear very quickly—

GW: Oh, no, my mother had me taking lessons when I was four years old. And I played classical music until I was 16 or 17 and found out I couldn't make a dime doing it, so it just was the wrong time. So I just gravitated to jazz. And it's been good to me. I can't complain at all.

MR: Right. What kind of experience did you have during the war years?

GW: Oh lovely. I was in Fort Lewis, Washington from 1944 to 46, and I was with a Special Service Unit. And we didn't have to do too much except play for the parades on a Saturday. The rest of the time I was in Seattle.

MR: What did you play for the parades?

GW: Beg pardon?

MR: What did you play for the parades?

GW: Oh I played glockenspiel sometimes, or I'd take a clarinet out, or a trombone. I had a working knowledge of them you know. I wasn't good at it but I could fake it pretty good.

MR: And in Seattle, when you were still in the service, what was going on there?

GW: Well I had a job then, yeah, I had a steady job. I worked with a saxophone player by the name of Tooty Boyd who has passed on since then, but we used to drive down to Portland for a job and I had some jobs in Seattle on Jackson Street, which was a hot street in Seattle at that time. So I made more outside of the Army than I made in the Army.

MR: Yeah? Today we think of a gig as usually nine to one, ten to two, sometimes less than that. What was a typical night like back then?

GW: Well when I was working, I had a gig in Greenwich Village and that was eight at night until four in the morning.

MR: Lord.

GW: And then I started working uptown and Monroe's Uptown House and we'd go to work about eleven thirty and get off at daylight. But that was all I needed because all I'd do is go up the hill and go to school. My first class was 7:30 so I was in business. I'd play all night and sleep in school all day.

MR: I was going to say, how can you handle that?

GW: Well now my history teacher moved out here, and she pulled the cover off me. She told my wife she says, "Yeah I often wondered why Gerry was so sleepy in class — I found out."

MR: He was a working man already. That's great. And the atmosphere in New York at that time was pretty happening, right?

GW: Oh, New York was great because especially for a youngster trying to learn the music business. Because the older guys would show you everything, you know, whatever you asked, you couldn't do it but they'd show you. I know I asked Tatum several times to show me certain things, he'd say, "Oh, Gerry," [scats]. I'd say thanks.

MR: Slow motion please?

GW: But Art got me the gig with Stepin Fetchit.

MR: Yeah?

GW: Yeah he got me my first gig.

MR: Was the average piano player intimidated by Art Tatum?

GW: No, they just wished he'd go away, you know. One guy told me he says, "Wig, don't worry about Art Tatum" he says, "much as he plays, he can only be in one place at one time, and he can't work all the gigs all at once so you're safe." Which makes sense.

MR: Right.

GW: Art was really a sweetheart. He was a nice man, except he didn't want to talk music, he wanted to talk baseball. You know he could tell you the average of Ty Cobb or anybody years before, you know? And how much they batted and what they did and all that. He was a good pinochle player too.

MR: Interesting. You have accompanied along the way some great singers, too.

GW: Yeah, I've been with Lena Horne, Dinah Washington, Kay Starr, I even was with Dinah Shore one night. And let's see who else. So many I forget most of them, yeah.

MR: Did you ever cross paths with Joe Williams?

GW: Oh, I see Joe all the time. Every time he comes to L.A. he usually hired my trio, yeah. His piano player doesn't want to make the trip out here so I get the job, which is great for me.

MR: What's it like working with Joe?

GW: Easiest job on earth. But I don't have to play his regular stuff. You know when he works with his piano player, they have all this stuff set up. But when he comes out here he says, "Wig, don't worry about it." The blues. We do the blues in any — all kind of keys. We do a ballad now and then, but it's very easy working for him.

MR: That's interesting. You know the non-jazz musician always finds it fascinating when if you watch someone and they say B flat, and that's all the band needs. You know, that's one great thing about —

GW: Well you're supposed to know the tunes, you know?

MR: That's another thing — for this type of festival, too, when you watch the bands up there, and you've really got to have a repertory in your head of tunes. Because some of them aren't groups that work together all the time, so someone turns around and says, you know, this particular tune—

GW: You better know it.

MR: In E flat, and you better know it.

GW: Yeah. Any key they call you're supposed to be able to play it.

MR: Yeah. When did you start doing, you did some vocal coaching in the studios out here?

GW: I did a little of it yeah.

MR: How did you get into that?

GW: Well people would call me since I'd worked with Lena and all the different people they figured I knew something about singers. I started believing them too.

MR: And you would do that for the studios?

GW: Oh, no, the only person I really coached in the studio was Marilyn Monroe. I got that job through Jackie Mills who used to be a drummer with Tommy Dorsey, and he had an in with Jack Cole, the choreographer. So he took me out of the studio one day and Jack Cole liked what I did so every time Marilyn did a musical, I was there.

MR: I read that it took her a lot of takes to get, in films sometimes. Is that true?

GW: Well she wasn't a singer per se you know, but she worked hard at it. And Jack Cole changed her style so much. He gave her things to do that she could half talk and half sing. So it came off pretty good for her.

MR: Did you, were you involved with "Some Like It Hot?"

GW: Well yeah, but that was mostly, what was it Jack Lemmon? Who was in that?

MR: Jack Lemmon and Tony Curtis.

GW: And Tony Curtis, yeah. And I didn't have too much to do with that but I was in "Les Girls," what is it "Let's Make Love," about five or six of them.

MR: I think I read you worked with Spike Jones?

GW: Yeah well, that happened, that's right. I was working with Spike's wife, Helen Grayco. And Spike's piano player Arnold Ross became ill, so Spike asked Helen could he borrow me for a while. So I went on the road with the Spike Jones band. And that was a trip. I said this crazy music, this ought to be fun to play. I think the first tune was "Poet and Peasant" for real. You know so if you couldn't read you were in a whole lot of trouble. Fortunately I could read. That was tough music.

MR: Yeah, you had to be good to play in that.

GW: And everything was timed to the second. And there was no goofing on that gig, believe me. Spike was a funny man but he was a taskmaster too, you know, you had to do it. I remember the first time I went to his home I walked in and there was a picture of the Blue Boy with Spike's head on top of it, which cracked me up. But then the next picture was Whistler's Mother with a racing form in her lap. And that was Spike all the way. He used to go to all the dog kennels when we were traveling, and tape the dogs barking and everything, and they put a record together of "Memories are Made of Things Like This" or something. He put all those dogs barking and this tune was fantastic.

MR: What an imagination.

GW: Oh he was something else, he was fantastic, yeah, I really loved him.

MR: And we listen to that stuff now and we remember that it was done without any studio tricks, just live.

GW: Oh yeah, that was just him editing and putting it together.

MR: That's interesting. They had some hot players though, to pull that stuff off.

GW: Oh, yeah. He had George Rock who was a fantastic trumpet player. And the tenor player Gil Bernal, he's still around. He called me a couple of years ago, he's been on the same job out here for about 30 years. I'd wondered what happened to him, you know. And there was Mousey, and oh what was the little midget's name?

MR: Oh, I remember from the T.V. shows they did, that guy running out on stage, the real small one.

GW: Yeah. Billy Barty. Yeah he was there. Yeah, Spike had quite a show.

MR: In what kind of venue — where would you play with him? In what kind of setting?

GW: Oh we did all the college gyms.

MR: College gyms.

GW: Yeah. In the middle of winter. And it was something else. It wasn't bad. I had a lot of fun.

MR: You've had some nice albums on your own. Who are the guys that you like to play with? Anybody special nowadays?

GW: Oh, now I use Paul Humphrey on drums and Andy Simpkins on bass. But on occasion I use Sherman Ferguson and other guys, you know. This town is full of good drummers and good bass players so you're never at a loss for a good rhythm section.

MR: What kind of traveling in other parts of the world have you been able to do.

GW: Oh, when I was with singers I did quite a bit of travel, especially with Helen Humes, we used to go to Europe every year for George Wein. But she passed away in I guess it was '81. So I don't go out too much now. If I go out it's for a couple of days or so. You know, I don't want anything steady. I had enough of steady work.

MR: Yeah? I'm glad to hear that you can take what you want.

GW: Well it's not so much that, I just, I'm an old man. I can't stand that anymore.

MR: And you've been in L.A. for how long? A long time?

GW: Well like I said I first got out here in 1940, but I didn't stay then. But the weather got to me. It was Christmas Day and a hundred degrees here, and in New York is was like ice, snow, and everything else. I immediately called my mother and said I found God's country, don't look for me in New York anymore. I went back naturally but when I got a chance to settle here I did.

MR: What do you think of the state of jazz today?

GW: It's the same as it's always been with youngsters coming up with new ideas. I know when — I'm from more or less the bop era, and the older guys didn't understand what we were doing and we didn't know what we were doing either, but we were doing something you know? It evolved into bop. Well the kids are doing the same thing now. They want their own voice and their own sound and that's what they're doing. Now you can either like it or not like it, but it's here, and it's not going away.

MR: Yeah. And if you don't like it you don't have to listen to it.

GW: So well yeah, but I found out you have to listen to find out what they're doing. And it's new so it's strange, so you have to get used to — give it a good listen and find out what they're doing. I know the first time I heard bop well I'd been around Dizzy quite a bit, so he was just getting it together, you know with the flat fives and raised ninths. And nobody knew what he was doing. He used to drive little trumpet players crazy. I was working in a place called Monroe's Uptown House and we had two trumpet players: Vic Coulson and Joe Treadwell who later married Sarah Vaughan. They bought themselves a couple of cornets and it was terrible to hear them try to play like Diz, I mean they were in bad shape. But they tried.

MR: Wasn't that the place where Thelonious Monk was doing some of that early —

GW: No that was downtown. That was, oh what was the name of that joint? But Monroe's Uptown House was in Harlem, about 134th or 135th Street. But the place you're talking about, how can I forget it?

MR: Minton's?

GW: Minton's. Minton's Playhouse, yeah. That's where Monk was.

MR: Did you notice when jazz moved from the Swing Era I guess into the bop, when bop became real popular, was there a loss of audience? Or did that affect your career at all? I mean the music changed drastically after World War II.

GW: Well I joined Benny Carter about that time. And I was kidding him I says, "Are we going to start playing bop?" And he says, "Well you're playing it already." I said, "Oh, good." Benny Carter had a big influence on my career because he's a superhuman guy. That guy is unbelievable. He can write, he can play, and he's a nice man which helps a lot you know.

MR: What's in your future? Do you do these festivals quite often?

GW: Yeah, I do them. I do Sarasota, New Jersey, you name it. This is easy. You do a couple of days, three days at the most, and come home. This time I'm home so it doesn't matter. But it's fun, and they pay the bills. It's not like sitting on a steady job working from nine to one or nine to two every night. That I couldn't do anymore. For no amount of money. It's just—

MR: It's a long gig.

GW: I'm just not geared that way I can't even stay in a club a week. I get antsy after one or two days and I want out.

MR: Did you ever get in a position, either in the studio or someone ask you to play any electronics? Electronic pianos or anything like that?

GW: Not really. I remember my first rhythm & blues record date the guy said, "Okay, Wig, now we're going to do this tune." And I'm all set you know, I'm full of it and I'm going to show him what I know. And he said, "Okay, now, right here I want you to play a bad chord." So I reached out, and I said, I'm gonna shock him with this. And I played this chord. He said, "No. I want you to play it like you don't know anything about the piano and you've got gloves on. I mean a bad chord." That was my first and last rock & roll date.

MR: Wow. Whose session was that do you remember?

GW: I forget. It's been so long ago. But I said, you know, he really wanted me to play like I didn't know how to play the piano. I felt insulted.

MR: Well, seeing as how you put all that time into learning how to—

GW: Yeah. They never called me again, believe me.

MR: What was your definition when you went to play that bad chord? Do you remember what kind of thing you might have played?

GW: Oh I was trying to play a polytonal type thing, you know.

MR: Yeah? One in one hand and one in the other. Yeah.

GW: But he wasn't having any of that. He wanted me to play like I didn't know what the piano was for. And I was really crushed.

MR: We've had a couple of people talk about reacting to what producers wanted.

GW: Yeah well they're looking for something, they're looking for something to sell you know. As he said, "I want you to act like you don't know what the piano is for, just hit something."

MR: Do you have any road stories that you can share with us?

GW: I can't tell them, no. I can't even write a book about them.

MR: They don't translate on to film, huh?

GW: Well, my lips are sealed, believe me.

MR: How about the best road experience you had, either with Les Hite or anybody from—

GW: Well I had fun with all the gigs I had, with the singers and the bands, you know. There were good times and bad times. I think the worst time I had was when I joined Louis Armstrong. I joined Louis out here, and we made 50 one nighters, all through the south. And at that time the south was pretty bad. So two weeks before we got to New York, I put in my notice. I loved the band and everything but I just couldn't stand what we were going through. It wasn't very nice. Anyhow we got to New York and I was home about three or four days and Benny Carter called me. He says, "Wig, you want to go take a trip to the west coast?" I said, "Yeah." I said, "You're not going south are you?" He said, "Oh, no, don't even think about that." I got on the train with Bumps Myers and I went to sleep and I woke up and I was in Macon, Georgia. I'd like to die. I gave him my notice right then and there. And he said, "Okay." And that was the end of it. And J.J. Johnson and Max Roach they say, "Oh Wig, come on" you know. So a couple of days later I went to Benny and I said, "About that notice I gave you I'd like to take it back." He said, "What notice?" I said, "Oh, okay."

MR: Was there a difference in that tour than with Louis?

GW: Well we didn't stay there. Benny wasn't about to stay down there.

MR: Just passing through.

GW: Pass through, yeah.

MR: Louis went down in the south quite a bit, didn't he?

GW: Well that was his territory. It sure wasn't mine.

MR: What was it like musically working with him?

GW: Well I never knew because with Louis we just played a gig and get out of town. We really didn't have a chance to meet anybody. By the time you got there it was time to play. When you finished you packed up and on to the next town. We were making like 500 mile jumps every night. So it was a little rough.

MR: Any chances to go overseas with some of the singers?

GW: Oh yeah. My first time overseas was with Lena Horne. That was 1950. That was a ball because I got a chance to play the London Palladium, you know, and that was, to me, really something. And we traveled all over Europe. We went to Spain, Sweden, [inaudible] wherever that is, Belgium I guess. It was a ball. And then when I joined Helen Humes we used to go over every year with George Wein's jazz thing. So I spent a lot of time in Europe. I made a lot of friends over there.

MR: Helen Humes. She was with Basie for a while wasn't she?

GW: Yeah. She was with Basie. Now she could have told you some things about Basie and the band. You would have loved to talk to her. Too bad she's gone.

MR: Was the Basie band something that you listened to off and on? We've talked with some people about the sound of their rhythm section. Was that something that —

GW: Oh, they had a tight rhythm section, yeah. They were together. You don't find that anymore. Yeah with Papa Jo Jones and whoever the bass player was, and Basie, and Freddie on guitar. Jesus.

MR: Can't do any better than that.

GW: Couldn't beat that. Yeah they had a thing going. But bands are not like that today. They're not, well to have a band like that, the piano player's got to be the leader, to keep a rhythm section together. And most days now, it's a trumpet player or a saxophone player, and they don't stress that as much.

MR: Well we've enjoyed talking with you very much. If you have any last things you'd like to say that I haven't thought of —

GW: Well, if you see my friend Allen Tinney, tell him hello. I think he's in Buffalo now.

MR: Umm — that's not far from us.

GW: Yeah, now he's a guy who would have some good stories for you about New York, with Tinney, and Bud Powell and myself. That's another thing. We won't go into that. You get that from him.

MR: Okay. Well on behalf of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, we'd like to thank Gerald Wiggins for this time together, and hope that your next festival is a lot of fun, and thanks for your time.

GW: All right.